

Mendel University in Brno
Faculty of Regional Development and International Studies

**"I will tell you how you can support us": Development assistance in
Zambia**

Bachelor Thesis

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1 INTRODUCTION

Development assistance represents a large component of global capital, goods, or services transferred to African continent every year. According to UNESCO (2021) majority of external assistance in forms of grants creates significant portion of governments' incomes in Sub-Saharan Africa. In the 1970s, countries within the United Nations agreed to allocate nearly one percent of their national income to official development assistance (Lancaster, 2007). Development assistance is encompassing financial, material, and non-material support, and it is provided by national agencies or non-governmental organizations to promote development and address crises in foreign countries or international organizations (Herre et. al., 2024). Although its primary objective is to reduce poverty and stimulate development, the reality often diverges from this intention (Riddell, 2008). In many African countries, poverty levels continue to rise despite decades of foreign assistance (Morgenstern & Brown, 2022; Moyo, 2009). Moreover, Abbott (1973) further argues that all forms of development assistance come with unintended side effects, which are frequently overlooked by donor countries. As the development discourse matures, greater emphasis is placed on the perspectives and agency of recipients (Thomas et al., 2014). This shift is visible not only in policy frameworks but also in academic research that seeks to understand how local actors perceive and request development assistance. The adoption of the term "development assistance" in this thesis, rather than the broader and sometimes politically loaded term "foreign aid," reflects a normative commitment to long-term, inclusive, and participatory development (Riddell, 2008; Lancaster, 2007). Unlike foreign aid, which may include strategic transfers, development assistance implies a deliberate, constructive effort toward sustainable progress in the Global South.

There are many scholars delving further into this problematic, but there is no existing common agreement on the fact if development assistance brings positive or negative impact on country's development (Lensink & White, 1998). As Abbott (1973) shows, development assistance can be either a concept of political tool or economic policy, where the donor must decide which path he chooses, but in both situations development assistance is a mechanism whose primary purpose is to complement domestic resources while also facilitating the generation of additional internal funding to promote development and social transformation in recipient countries. Development assistance

may yield positive outcomes in the short term; however, its long-term effects often appear detrimental, as it fosters dependency and reinforces poverty traps (Glennie, 2008). Recipients of such assistance frequently become reliant on external support rather than seeking alternative pathways for sustainable development (Lensink & White, 1998). Consequently, while other global economic powers have transitioned from underdeveloped to industrialized status, much of Africa has experienced limited visible progress in recent decades (Moyo, 2009).

Issue of development assistance dependency ¹in Africa leads to corruption, inflation, weakened institutions, and reduced domestic investment (Andersson et al., 2000), while also fostering complacency among policymakers who perceive assistance as a permanent source of income rather than seeking alternative financial strategies such as foreign direct investment or debt markets (Moyo, 2009). Similar patterns can be observed in Zambia, when since its post-independence reforms, the country has experienced a significant influx of donor support, particularly since the 1980s, Zambia has received foreign assistance from international multilateral institutions such as the World Bank and the IMF, as well as from national governments, initially led by Nordic countries, with various other donors entering and exiting over time (Andersson et al, 2000). This influx of assistance has been accompanied by conditions related to democratization, the promotion of human rights, and broader developmental objectives (UNU-WIDER, 2013). Over the past two decades, Zambia has undergone significant economic and social changes. Despite some progress, it continues to face significant challenges, particularly in the areas of education and nutrition, which remain critical concerns for much of the population (World Bank Group, 2020). Moreover, poverty has deepened over the past two decades, with the proportion of people living below the international poverty line now exceeding 60% (World Bank Group, 2023). Paradoxically, these difficulties persist alongside notable economic expansion. Over the last 20 years, Zambia's GDP has grown, reflecting substantial macroeconomic progress (World Bank Group, 2024b). Additionally, unemployment has declined, access to electricity has improved, and the country's population has nearly doubled in the same period (World Bank Group, 2024a; World Bank Group, 2024c; World Bank Group, 2025). This apparent contradiction underscores the complexity of Zambia's development path, where economic growth does not

¹ In this thesis, the terms "assistance dependency" and "aid dependency" are used interchangeably.

necessarily translate into widespread improvements in living conditions, highlighting the need for more inclusive and sustainable policies.

Understanding the dynamics of development assistance dependency is crucial for designing policies that empower local actors, reduce reliance on external support, and foster sustainable development (Glennie, 2008). By exploring the ways in which these organizations navigate their dependence on development assistance, we can gain valuable insights into the broader implications of aid dependency and the potential pathways to more resilient and independent development systems (Lensink & White, 1998). As Abbott (1973) expresses there is a well-documented gap between the theoretical framework and the actual practice of foreign assistance, and he argues that most analyses are conducted from the donor's perspective, which influenced the author of this thesis to formulate research objectives and questions from a different standpoint.

The primary objective of this thesis is to bring insight into how diverse actors within development projects in Zambia have or have not become dependent on various types of foreign assistance and to explore their reasoning behind seeking and participating in such projects. This raises the broader question of whether Zambia, as one of the countries in Sub-Saharan Africa, is dependent on development assistance. However, this issue remains contested within academic discourse, with no definitive consensus. To explore this issue, the following research questions will be examined:

1. What motivations drive diverse actors to seek and participate in foreign-funded development projects?
2. What forms of development assistance are most sought by participants in development projects?
3. What strategies do these actors employ to secure external support?

1.1 Literature review

Theoretical contributions examining the influence of development assistance in Sub-Saharan Africa, particularly those that focus on power asymmetries and the negotiation of local agency, have proven especially valuable in understanding the complexities of aid dependency. Key authors such as Lie (2008), Brown (2005), and Long (2001) have provided significant frameworks for analysing how external assistance interacts with local social structures and decision-making processes. Long's (2001) theoretical

contributions in development sociology emphasize the agency of local actors, demonstrating how they shape and translate development processes, such as commoditization and institutionalization, and he argues that these dynamics acquire meaning through the situated practices and interactions of actors, and further explores the interplay of knowledge, power, and discourse in rural contexts. Lie (2008), on the other hand, examines how development discourse is constructed and sustained through selective knowledge use, reinforcing “truths” about people and events, and emphasizing the connection between language, power, and the self-reinforcing nature of dominant narratives. Brown (2005), in contrast to the actor-oriented and discourse-focused approaches of Long (2001) and Lie (2008), centres his analysis on the political dimensions of development. He focuses particularly on how foreign donors contribute to sustaining authoritarian regimes and influencing prolonged democratic transitions in African countries. When applied to the issue of dependency on development assistance, this theoretical approach provides a unique perspective on the analysis of dependency. Several scholars have contributed to this field, including Moyo (2009), Lancaster (2007), Rakner (2003), and Lensink & White (1998). Moyo (2009) argues that long-term development assistance has failed to foster sustainable growth in Africa and instead perpetuates a cycle of dependency, proposing market-based alternatives as more effective solutions. Lancaster (2007) offers a comprehensive analysis of official development assistance and foreign aid as tools of both diplomacy and development. She provides critical insights into how development assistance policies are shaped and implemented, although she does not directly address aid dependency. Rakner (2003) explores the role of development assistance in Zambia’s democratization processes, focusing on the political implications of donor involvement, even though she does not emphasize economic dependency. Lensink & White (1998) list indicators related to environmental, social, and economic factors that can be used to monitor the impacts and progress of aid dependence.

In addition to these scholars, several authors critically examine the broader impact of development assistance on governance, institutions, and economic growth in Africa. Bräutigam & Knack (2004) asserts that continued high levels of development assistance can undermine public governance in Sub-Saharan Africa. Empirical analyses in their work reveal a negative correlation between development assistance and the quality of governance. Easterly (2010) critiques the inefficiency of foreign assistance, particularly

its bureaucratic issues, and expresses scepticism about the ability of development assistance to foster long-term economic growth. However, his criticism underscores doubt about the long-term positive impact of this assistance. In one of the newest books Frankema et al. (2023) focus on defining development and emphasize the importance of historical and environmental perspectives in understanding economic development. They analyse how these factors influence the conceptualization of "development" and its relevance in the African context. Overall, the literature highlights that while development assistance may have potential benefits, such as fostering economic growth and improving governance, it also presents significant challenges, including perpetuating dependency and undermining local governance structures.

The rest of the thesis continues as follows. The first chapter discusses Zambia's development trajectory, focusing on its historical context, postcolonial progress, and socio-economic developments over the past two decades, while also addressing critiques of development assistance and dependency, and highlighting the importance of a donor-driven approach. The second chapter presents methodological approaches, while the third chapter explores the research findings and conclusions. The discussion chapter critically assesses Zambia's reliance on development assistance and examines potential pathways for reducing dependency and achieving self-sufficiency.

2 ZAMBIA AND DEVELOPMENT ASSISTANCE

The decision to focus this research on Zambia as a study area is both deliberate and significant. As a lower-middle-income country with a long and complex history of foreign development assistance, Zambia offers a compelling example for understanding the dynamics, impacts, and limitations of international development assistance in Sub-Saharan Africa. With decades of experience as both a partner and a recipient of bilateral and multilateral development assistance, Zambia provides valuable insights into how foreign support interacts with domestic policies, economic structures, and institutional capacities. Furthermore, Zambia's post-independence trajectory, marked by economic booms and busts, debt crises, political transitions, and sectoral reforms, closely mirrors many of the challenges faced by other African states navigating the post-colonial development landscape. Zambia is particularly relevant to the academic debates surrounding assistance dependency, the effectiveness of development assistance modalities, and the conditionalities imposed by international donors. As scholars such as Moyo (2009), Riddell (2008), and Easterly (2010) have argued, understanding the real-world consequences of long-term assistance engagement requires nuanced, context-specific analyses that go beyond aggregate data. Zambia's extensive exposure to diverse forms of development assistance, from structural adjustment programs and technical assistance to project-based interventions and budgetary support, makes it a valuable case through which to examine both the transformative potential and unintended consequences of foreign assistance. In addition, Zambia's status as a stable regime with democratic foundations and relatively peaceful political transitions allows for a more controlled observation of assistance outcomes, as external shocks and violent conflict have not been primary disruptors of development progress (UNU-WIDER, 2013). Instead, the Zambian experience reflects the tensions between donor-driven priorities and local ownership, as well as the persistent struggle to balance short-term needs with long-term capacity building and economic sustainability (Andersson et. al., 2000).

By situating Zambia at the centre of this research, the study aims to contribute to a more grounded understanding of how foreign assistance functions in practice, how it is perceived and utilized by local actors, and what lessons can be drawn for future development cooperation. The following chapter therefore provides a historical and thematic overview of development assistance in Zambia. This country has been a

recipient of development assistance since gaining independence from British colonial rule in 1964. Initially, foreign assistance was directed primarily toward infrastructure development, basic social services, and economic growth, with the aim of facilitating the transition from colonial administration to self-governance (Clark & Allison, 1989). In the early years, Zambia benefitted from robust economic performance, largely driven by copper exports, which allowed the country to maintain relative independence from external assistance (Andersson et al., 2000). However, in the 1970s, global copper price fluctuations, compounded by economic mismanagement and ineffective planning, led to a sharp economic downturn and growing dependency on development assistance (ibid). Throughout the 1980s and 1990s, Zambia experienced deepening economic instability, prompting increased reliance on Structural Adjustment Programs (SAPs) introduced by the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank (Hambuba & van Leggelo-Padilla, 2022). These programs emphasized privatization, trade liberalization, and public sector reform (Hillbom, 2023). In theory, such measures were intended to modernize Zambia's economy and reduce inefficiencies. However, in practice, they were accompanied by significant social costs, including mass layoffs, increasing poverty, and reductions in government expenditure on essential services like education and healthcare (UNU-WIDER, 2013). In light of this thesis, it is important to note that although these adjustments were meant to promote long-term fiscal stability, they also eroded public trust and weakened the state's ability to fulfil its developmental responsibilities (Ferguson, 2006). By the late 1990s, as the process of democratic consolidation progressed, donor agencies began exerting more pressure on Zambia to implement governance and institutional reforms (UNU-WIDER, 2013). According to Andersson et al. (2000), tensions escalated between donors and the Zambian government, particularly as the country's capacity to implement reforms remained limited. In summary, this period marked a shift in the nature of development assistance from economic stabilization towards political conditionality and democratic support. In the 2000s, assistance strategies underwent further transformation, aligning with global development agendas. The adoption of the Millennium Development Goals reoriented donor priorities towards poverty reduction, health, education, and sustainable development (Rakner, 2003; UNU-WIDER, 2013). More recently, the Sustainable Development Goals have guided foreign assistance in Zambia, promoting a more integrated approach that encompasses economic, social, and environmental dimensions (Andersson et al., 2000). Development assistance

now seeks not only to alleviate poverty, but to address systemic inequalities, promote resilience, and support inclusive governance.

Historically, Zambia has received bilateral assistance from key Western donors, including the United States, the United Kingdom, Sweden, Germany, and Japan (Lancaster, 2007). Multilateral institutions, such as the World Bank, the African Development Bank, and various United Nations agencies, have played critical roles in shaping Zambia's development landscape (UNU-WIDER, 2013; Hambuba & van Leggelo-Padilla, 2022). In the past two decades, China has emerged as a significant development partner, particularly through its engagement in infrastructure and energy projects (van Wieringen & Zajontz, 2023). The nature and focus of foreign assistance have evolved considerably over the past decades. While early efforts emphasized physical infrastructure and social services, contemporary assistance increasingly targets institutional reform, democracy promotion, and market-oriented policies (U.S. Foreign Assistance, 2025). Nonetheless, there remains a consensus that Zambia continues to require elevated levels of external support to meet its fiscal obligations, potentially double the current levels (Lancaster, 2007). However, as Glennie (2008) notes, this need is complicated by limited administrative capacity, which constrains Zambia's ability to effectively absorb even the current levels of assistance. In light of this contradiction, assistance tends to be project-specific (UNESCO, 2021), and unconditional balance-of-payments support remains unlikely due to persistent concerns about governance and accountability (Andersson et al., 2000).

Development assistance has played a particularly vital role in Zambia's key development sectors. In education, it supported the emergence and rapid growth of the community school movement following the state's retreat from public service provision during SAPs. From nearly 40 community schools in 1996, the number expanded to over 2,400 by 2015, accounting for approximately 20% of all primary enrolments (MESVTEE, 2014). While many of these institutions have since been integrated into the state system, they continue to depend heavily on NGOs and local communities for funding, infrastructure, and curriculum implementation, and the Zambia Community Schools Secretariat has been instrumental in coordinating support and aligning community initiatives with national education policies (UNESCO, 2021). Development assistance not only filled institutional gaps in the sector of education but also spurred grassroots innovation and growth. In the

health sector, development assistance has been critical in addressing major public health challenges, including HIV/AIDS, tuberculosis, and malaria. Zambia has benefitted immensely from the Global Fund, which has provided substantial financial support for prevention and treatment programs, aligned with global health initiatives like UNAIDS's 90-90-90 target (UNAIDS, 2014). These efforts included the expansion of universal access to antiretroviral therapy, particularly for expectant mothers (The Global Fund, 2024). Furthermore, the Office of the Inspector General ensures that resources are effectively allocated, and mismanagement is minimized (U.S. Foreign Assistance, 2025). Health sector can be considered as one, which plays crucial role in development of a country, therefore these initiatives of development assistance might be key components of sustainable growth. Agriculture, employing over 70% of the Zambian population, 78% of whom are women, remains central to Zambia's economy and development strategy (FAO, 2020; USADF, 2023). Donor-supported programs such as the Scaling Up Nutrition initiative, the Eastern Kafue Alliance, and Prosper Africa have promoted sustainable farming practices, improved irrigation, and strengthened food security (FAO et al., 2020). The World Bank's Agricultural Development Support Program (ADSP), implemented through the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock, has aimed to assist smallholder farmers with commercialization and value-chain development (IFAD, 2018; Thomas et al., 2014). In light of these interventions, agriculture continues to be a priority for inclusive growth.

In addition to capacity building in technical education, and public health, donors have contributed to physical infrastructure (Moyo, 2009). Development assistance has also facilitated large-scale infrastructure investments, particularly in transportation, energy, and water access. Chinese-funded projects, including roads, bridges, and railways such as TAZARA, can serve as examples of influential projects (Foster & Dominguez, 2010). However, scholars caution that infrastructure investments alone are insufficient unless paired with institutional and policy reforms to ensure long-term economic gains (Andersson et al., 2000). Governance-focused assistance has supported electoral reforms, anti-corruption efforts, and human rights promotion. Such assistance has been pivotal in nurturing a vibrant civil society in Zambia, including NGOs, legal associations, and religious institutions (UNU-WIDER, 2013). Nevertheless, as the majority of assistance continues to flow through executive agencies, concerns persist that this approach may inadvertently reinforce the power of the state at the expense of civil society participation

(ibid). Overall, while donor support has been essential to Zambia's democratic transition, its effectiveness remains uneven.

Beyond sectoral impacts, development assistance has significantly influenced Zambia's macroeconomic landscape. According to Andersson et al. (2000), despite extensive foreign assistance, Zambia has struggled to diversify its exports and achieve sustainable growth. In the 1990s, high assistance inflows paradoxically allowed the government to delay critical reforms. Rakner (2003) argues that this overreliance on assistance hindered genuine economic adjustment, creating dependency rather than resilience. Conversely, some analysts point to the successful deregulation of Zambia's economy and the promotion of market mechanisms as a long-term success of donor-supported liberalization (UNU-WIDER, 2013). In summary, the relationship between development assistance and economic development remains complex and context-dependent, as Zambia's debt burden has further increased the importance of development assistance. High levels of debt service in the 1990s often offset assistance inflows, exacerbating fiscal pressure (Andersson et al., 2000). Donor efforts to restructure debt and provide budget support have been essential to Zambia's financial stability, though the long-term sustainability of such assistance remains contested, but investment patterns also reveal that funds directed into the private sector generally have a greater multiplier effect on consumption and productivity than those allocated to public administration (ibid). As part of broader economic reforms, the World Bank promoted a reduction of state control and an expansion of market forces (Clark & Allison, 1989), with mixed outcomes in terms of equity and inclusion.

Zambia provides a compelling case study of how donor-driven assistance shapes national policy, institutional development, and sectoral priorities. Historically, Zambia has implemented structural adjustment programs, which included market liberalization, privatization, and fiscal austerity (Rakner, 2003; Mosley et al., 1995). While these reforms aimed to stabilize the economy, they also generated significant social costs, including reductions in education and healthcare spending (Clark & Allison, 1989). To comply with donor requirements, Zambia established specialized institutions such as the Ministry of Finance and the Zambia Development Agency to manage assistance coordination and policy alignment (Whitfield, 2009). However, these institutions often struggle with limited administrative capacity and bureaucratic inefficiencies, which hinder the

implementation of donor-funded programs (Andersson et al., 2000). Donor influence is particularly evident in sectoral prioritization (Moyo, 2009). Education and health have attracted substantial funding from donors such as USAID and the Global Fund, leading to targeted interventions in areas like HIV/AIDS and primary education (U.S. Foreign Assistance, 2025). In contrast, sectors not favoured by donors—such as tertiary education or local enterprise development—remain underfunded, potentially distorting national development trajectories (World Bank, 2021).

The sustainability of development assistance continues to pose a challenge. Many NGOs and civil society organizations remain heavily dependent on external funding, making them vulnerable to shifting donor priorities and global financial trends (Rakner, 2003). As international focus increasingly shifts towards trade-based models and local ownership, questions arise about the future of assistance as a tool for sustainable development. Scholars such as Moyo (2009) argue for a gradual shift from assistance to trade, emphasizing the need to foster entrepreneurship, improve market access, and reduce donor dependency. However, achieving such a transformation requires substantial investment in human capital, infrastructure, and institutional development (UNCTAD, 2018).

3 CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORKS

3.1 Development assistance

Development assistance has evolved as a cornerstone of international development policy, reflecting not only the global commitment to alleviating poverty and fostering human development but also the strategic interests of donor countries. Over the decades, the terminology, structure, and objectives of these assistance flows have undergone significant transformation, shifting from charity-based transfers to more strategic, targeted, and partnership-oriented mechanisms. Development assistance today encompasses a wide array of financial, technical, and institutional support systems aimed at fostering sustainable growth in low- and middle-income countries (Todaro & Smith, 2020; Riddell, 2008). In its modern form, Official Development Assistance (ODA) remains the primary vehicle of development financing. Defined and monitored by the Development Assistance Committee of the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, ODA refers to resource flows from donor governments to developing countries or multilateral institutions with the explicit objective of promoting economic development and welfare, and it must include at least a 25% grant element (Lancaster, 2007). These flows exclude military assistance and are strictly geared toward civilian objectives, such as education, health, infrastructure, and governance reforms. Development assistance can be disbursed bilaterally—directly from one government to another—or multilaterally through institutions such as the World Bank, the United Nations Development Programme, or regional development banks. The list of leading donors in last 10 years has included the United States, the European Union, the International Development Association, the United Kingdom, Germany, the United Arab Emirates, France, the Global Fund, the African Development Bank, and Japan, all donating billions of US dollars (Nyandoro & Dube, 2023). This donor landscape illustrates the diversity of actors involved in assistance provision, each with distinct geopolitical motivations, historical ties, and thematic priorities. In addition to financial assistance, development assistance comprises technical assistance as the transfer of expertise, skills, and institutional capacities. This form of assistance seeks to complement financial resources by strengthening local governance structures, providing training for civil servants, or facilitating the implementation of public sector reforms (Todaro & Smith, 2020). As such, development assistance becomes not only a transfer of material

resources but also of knowledge systems, intended to generate lasting institutional and human capacity.

We can say that over time, the focus of development assistance has shifted from input-based measures to outcomes and impact assessments. This evolution reflects broader changes in the international development discourse. In the early decades following World War II, foreign assistance was largely seen through a charitable or geopolitical lens. Resources were transferred from the Global North to the Global South with the intention of supporting economic recovery, preventing the spread of communism, or fostering diplomatic alliances (Riddell, 2008; Moyo, 2009). However, with time, this one-directional perspective was increasingly challenged. Fowler (2000) identifies a paradigmatic shift from charity to partnership, which gained traction in the 1970s through the work of non-governmental development organizations (NGDOs). These organizations began advocating for solidarity-based models of cooperation that emphasized shared responsibility and mutual accountability. Later, under the leadership of the World Bank, development institutions began to reposition recipient governments in a steering role, especially regarding poverty alleviation efforts (Lancaster, 2007). This shift was institutionalized in international policy frameworks, most notably the Paris Declaration on Aid Effectiveness in 2005 and the Accra Agenda for Action in 2008 (Riddell, 2008). These documents emphasized five core principles: ownership, alignment, harmonization, managing for results, and mutual accountability. Donors were urged to align their interventions with recipient countries' development strategies, utilize local systems, and report transparently on results (Thomas et. al., 2011). This marked a clear move away from top-down, donor-driven models and toward more participatory, results-oriented development cooperation. Yet, despite these advances, significant critiques remain. Scholars such as Riddell (2008) and Moyo (2009) argue that development assistance continues to be shaped by donor interests—whether strategic, diplomatic, or economic. These dual motives can distort priorities, weaken local accountability, and lead to inefficient use of resources.

In operational terms, the notion of a development intervention offers a useful analytical lens. Long (2001) in summary describes a development intervention as a set of intentional, coordinated activities introduced by governments, international organizations, or NGOs, we can say external actors in general, to stimulate developmental change within a given

society or economy. These interventions may target various sectors, including education, health, governance, or infrastructure, and are usually implemented as time-bound projects or programs (Belcher & Palenberg, 2018). While development interventions are the practical manifestations of development assistance, their design and execution often raise concerns (Brown, 2005). Belcher and Palenberg (2018) also note that externally driven interventions risk marginalizing local agency and undervaluing indigenous knowledge systems. Moreover, the term "intervention" may carry colonial connotations, particularly in post-colonial contexts where development practices are entangled with historical asymmetries and power dynamics (Long, 2001).

To evaluate the effectiveness of development assistance, a variety of assessment tools have emerged. Logical frameworks and results-based management systems provide structured approaches for planning, monitoring, and evaluating development activities (Lancaster, 2007). These frameworks delineate inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes, and long-term impacts, thereby creating a hierarchy of expected results. A pertinent example is the Smallholder Productivity Promotion Programme in Zambia, which included specific indicators, verification methods, and objectives for each tier of intervention outcomes (IFAD, 2018). Indicators play a central role in this evaluative process. In the education sector, they might include enrolment ratios, access to early learning environments, or improvements in learning outcomes (UNESCO, 2021). In health, indicators often focus on treatment adherence, mortality rates, or the success of disease prevention strategies (UNAIDS, 2014; Todaro & Smith, 2020). In the economic domain, metrics such as GDP growth, inflation control, or trade liberalization are frequently used. Burnside and Dollar's work, for instance, integrated fiscal, monetary, and trade policy indicators into growth regressions to assess assistance's impact on economic performance (Burnside & Dollar, 1997 cited in Andersson et al, 2000). Yet the measurement of assistance effectiveness is fraught with methodological challenges. Attribution remains one of the most problematic issues—establishing a causal link between a specific intervention and observed outcomes is notoriously difficult (Lancaster, 2007). Data reliability is another concern, especially in fragile or low-capacity contexts where monitoring systems are weak or absent. Definitions themselves may also vary, as OECD defines outcomes as short- to medium-term effects of outputs, while impacts refer to long-term changes, whether positive or negative, primary or secondary, however such distinctions are often contested and context-sensitive (Belcher & Palenberg, 2018).

Furthermore, development outcomes are typically shaped by a complex interplay of systemic factors (Frankema et. al., 2023b). Belcher & Palenberg (2018) argue that an intervention-based perspective may be too narrow, failing to account for broader political, economic, or environmental dynamics that influence change. A systems-oriented approach thus becomes essential for capturing the multifaceted nature of development processes. In recent years, randomized controlled trials (RCTs) have gained prominence as a tool for impact evaluation (Riddell, 2008). By isolating variables and controlling for external factors, RCTs aim to provide rigorous evidence of causality (UNESCO, 2021). However, their applicability is often limited by ethical concerns, contextual constraints, and high implementation costs. Moreover, the focus on measurable outcomes can risk sidelining more qualitative dimensions of development, such as empowerment, participation, or social cohesion (Todaro & Smith, 2020).

In conclusion, development assistance remains a central, yet contested, pillar of global development policy. Its implementation through financial transfers, technical support, and targeted interventions holds potential for transformative change, but its success depends on context-sensitive, partnership-based approaches that respect local knowledge and ownership. Understanding the evolution, complexity, and implications of development assistance is essential for assessing the expectations and needs of actors engaged in international cooperation.

3.2 Dependency on development assistance and criticism

Development assistance has long been considered a cornerstone of international development strategies aimed at addressing poverty, inequality, and institutional deficits in low-income countries. It serves as a significant mechanism for supporting development initiatives, providing financial assistance, technical expertise, and emergency relief (Bräutigam & Knack, 2004). However, despite its intended purpose of fostering progress, the provision of continuous assistance without accompanying mechanisms for local empowerment can give rise to a harmful phenomenon known as *assistance dependency* (Lensink & White, 1998).

Assistance dependency materializes when substantial assistance inflows persist without a corresponding emphasis on fostering self-sufficiency and capacity-building (Bräutigam & Knack, 2004). In such circumstances, foreign assistance ceases to serve as a catalyst

for independent development and instead entrenches patterns of reliance, undermining economic and institutional autonomy (Andersson et al., 2000). Although this issue can affect countries across different income brackets, it is particularly pronounced in various African nations, where governance structures often struggle to function independently due to systemic weaknesses (Bräutigam & Knack, 2004). Quantifying assistance dependency directly is a complex task, but it is commonly assessed by examining the ratio of net assistance inflows to a country's gross domestic product (Andersson et al., 2000). A country is generally considered assistance-dependent if it is unable to achieve specific developmental objectives without continued foreign assistance (Lensink & White, 1998). While many assistance-dependent states fall within the low-income category, this pattern is not absolute; middle-income countries may also exhibit similar reliance, especially when foreign assistance becomes a consistent component of the national budget or institutional financing (Thomas et. al., 2011). Importantly, this dependency dynamic is not limited to national governments. NGOs, which are often central actors in delivering services and implementing donor-funded projects, can also become assistance-dependent when their operations hinge on continued access to external funding (Bräutigam & Knack, 2004). This structural reliance can render both public and civil society sectors vulnerable to shifts in donor priorities and financing decisions, posing challenges for program continuity and long-term impact (Thomas et. al., 2011).

Multiple underlying factors contribute to the persistence and intensification of assistance dependency. Among the most prominent are corruption, weak institutional frameworks, limited transparency, bureaucratic inefficiencies, and inadequate state capacity (Moyo, 2009). Many African societies have historically faced such challenges, often exacerbated by the economic dislocations following independence and subsequent reliance on multilateral financial assistance (Riddell, 2008). Political instability—manifesting in coups, civil conflicts, or ineffective leadership—further undermines domestic economic resilience, discouraging investment, trade, and internal resource mobilization, and thus deepening dependency (Moyo, 2009). In parallel, macroeconomic problems such as inflation, the erosion of social capital, and declining domestic investment contribute to a self-perpetuating cycle of underdevelopment and external reliance, and the core risk of assistance dependency lies in its tendency to sustain underdevelopment rather than alleviate it (Bräutigam & Knack, 2004). This concern is encapsulated in what scholars have termed the *vicious circle of aid*, wherein continuous inflows of financial assistance

reduce incentives for reform and innovation (Lensink & White, 1998). Development assistance can inadvertently reinforce corrupt governance structures by providing regimes with unmonitored funds that are vulnerable to mismanagement or diversion away from priority sectors (Moyo, 2009). This dynamic weakens legal institutions, diminishes governmental accountability, and reduces both domestic and foreign investor confidence, all of which are crucial for sustained growth (Thomas et. al., 2011). In response to persistent poverty and institutional failure, donor agencies may paradoxically increase assistance allocations, thereby further entrenching the very dependency they seek to resolve (Moyo, 2009). The debate surrounding assistance dependency gained significant traction during the 1990s, as critical voices began to emphasize how excessive assistance can discourage the development of independent revenue-generation mechanisms (Riddell, 2008). Critics pointed to the stagnation of local tax systems and the limited growth of entrepreneurial activity as evidence that foreign assistance, in its conventional form, was failing to catalyse self-reliant development (Glennie, 2008). This critique prompted a shift in development thinking, advocating for approaches that emphasized financial independence, domestic institution-building, and long-term sustainability (Thomas et al., 2011). These strategies include strengthening tax collection, fostering local entrepreneurship, and channelling assistance into capacity-building efforts designed to reduce long-term reliance on donor support. Another frequently cited concern is the distortion of local markets and economic incentives resulting from large-scale, poorly managed development assistance inflows, when sudden injections of capital can disrupt price mechanisms, crowd out local producers, and create artificial economic conditions that undermine long-term stability (Glennie, 2008). In cases where governments lack policy autonomy or administrative capacity, donor priorities may override national agendas, further weakening domestic policy-making structures (Thomas et al., 2011). Consequently, governments may become more accountable to donors than to their own citizens, leading to misaligned development strategies and short-term project cycles that fail to produce transformative change (Riddell, 2008).

From a theoretical standpoint, the discourse on development assistance and its discontents is informed by two dominant frameworks: *Modernization Theory* and *Dependency Theory*. Modernization theorists argue that foreign assistance acts as a necessary catalyst for development by supplying capital, knowledge, and institutional models to underdeveloped nations, which are considered to be at an earlier stage of economic

evolution (Rostow, 1960; Todaro & Smith, 2020). As economic development proceeds, it is expected that a more educated middle class will emerge, leading to increased political participation and inclusive governance (Acemoglu & Robinson, 2012). In support of this view, empirical studies have shown that aid-backed investments in sectors such as education and health can significantly improve human development indicators, especially in the short term (Moyo, 2009). On the other hand, *Dependency Theory* offers a more critical perspective, positing that development assistance often serves the economic and geopolitical interests of donor countries, rather than addressing the structural disadvantages of recipient states (Frank, 1969; Amin, 1974). One of the primary criticisms from dependency theorists is that development assistance can diminish the incentive for recipient governments to build domestic revenue systems and engage in meaningful institutional reform (Lensink & White, 1998; Moyo, 2009). In addition, assistance often comes with conditions—such as structural reforms, liberalization policies, or privatization—that reflect donor priorities more than local needs, thus undermining sovereignty and ownership (Easterly, 2010).

In parallel, *Post-development Theory* offers an even more radical critique, challenging the very foundations of traditional development paradigms. Post-development theorists argue that foreign assistance often perpetuates neo-colonial relationships by enforcing Western models of progress and marginalizing indigenous knowledge systems and institutions (Lie, 2008). From this perspective, development assistance is not a neutral or benevolent tool but a mechanism of control that sustains inequality and dependency (Frank, 1969). Closely related to Dependency Theory, post-development thinking underscores the need for locally driven strategies that are responsive to cultural and historical contexts rather than externally imposed blueprints (Todaro & Smith, 2020).

Zambia exemplifies many of the tensions and contradictions associated with long-term assistance dependency (Andersson et al., 2000). While development assistance has played a critical role in financing public services such as education and healthcare, it has also entrenched budgetary reliance on external sources (Moyo, 2009). This pattern was especially evident during when structural adjustment programs required austerity measures, including cuts to public sector employment and subsidies (Mkandawire, 2005). These reforms disproportionately impacted vulnerable populations, eroded state capacity, and limited the government's ability to formulate independent development policies

(Brown, 2005). The privatization of state-owned enterprises—another condition of many assistance packages—frequently led to job losses, increased inequality, and public discontent (Ferguson, 2006). Similar patterns have been observed in countries such as Ghana and Malawi, where donor influence has significantly shaped national policies (Chisinga, 2011). For instance, in Malawi, agricultural subsidies financed by foreign donors have improved food security in the short term but raised concerns about long-term sustainability and the erosion of domestic agricultural innovation (Collier, 2007). In Zambia, the implications of assistance dependency are particularly visible in the education and healthcare sectors, where donor-funded programs often dictate national priorities and resource allocations (Glennie, 2008). While Modernization Theory may view these programs as necessary investments in human capital (Rostow, 1960; Todaro & Smith, 2020), post-development theorists would argue that they constrain the emergence of contextually relevant solutions and reinforce Western-centric models of development (Lie, 2008). The central challenge facing Zambia—and many similarly situated countries—is thus to reduce assistance dependency while fostering institutional resilience and locally owned development initiatives that are not shaped by external conditionalities.

While the emphasis on external support reflects the genuine needs and structural deficits in the local context, it also reveals certain patterns that raise questions about the risk of dependency on development assistance (Thomas et. al., 2014). This phenomenon is widely debated in development literature and has been critically assessed by numerous scholars. According to Lensink and White (1998), it can lead to “*donor fatigue*”, where continued reliance on external resources results in a stagnation or even decline in assistance flows. Over time, this relationship may create a *dependency mentality*, wherein governments or civil society actors become unable to imagine functioning independently of development assistance (Moyo, 2009). This can ultimately evolve into a “*dependency trap*”, where the assistance itself generates a continued need for more assistance (Lensink & White, 1998). Critics of assistance dependency increasingly advocate for alternatives that emphasize trade over assistance and this lines with an argument, popularized by economists like Moyo (2009), when he suggests that sustainable development is more likely to arise from investment, entrepreneurship, and expanded access to international markets than from continued financial transfers. These proponents argue that a focus on building infrastructure, improving governance, and investing in human capital can enable

developing countries to engage more competitively in the global economy without reliance on donor support (Chisinga, 2011). Thus, while foreign assistance remains an indispensable component of global solidarity, it is not a panacea. Without strategic interventions aimed at promoting domestic accountability, institutional capacity, and economic self-reliance, development assistance may inadvertently reinforce the very problems it seeks to resolve.

3.3 Donor driven approach and development sociology

Understanding the perspectives of assistance recipients is essential for a critical evaluation of development cooperation. This section focuses on how different forms of development assistance and funding strategies shape the priorities, policies, and practices of recipient states, NGOs, and individual recipients. While the intention behind foreign assistance is to support socio-economic development, its conditionalities and modalities often influence the autonomy and strategic decision-making of the actors on the ground (Glennie, 2008). The actor-oriented approach (Long, 2001) is particularly relevant here, as it emphasizes that development is not a one-directional process but rather a dynamic negotiation between donors and recipients. It is crucial to recognize that recipient actors are not merely passive beneficiaries of donor policies but active agents capable of adapting, resisting, or reshaping the influence of external funding (ibid).

The term "donor-driven approach" refers to situations where the priorities, strategies, and implementation mechanisms of development initiatives are primarily determined by donors rather than by recipient governments or local communities (Rakner, 2003). In such cases, donors establish the development agenda, select targeted sectors, and impose specific conditions to access funding, and donor agendas are often aligned with political and economic objectives that reflect the interests of their own constituencies (Todaro & Smith, 2020). As Rakner (2003) notes, bilateral donors must justify development assistance spending to national assemblies and taxpayers, which leads them to emphasize issues such as good governance, democracy, and human rights, especially after the end of the Cold War. In this context, development assistance becomes not only a tool for poverty alleviation but also a vehicle for promoting ideological and strategic goals. The technocratic orientation of bilateral assistance can result in a limited understanding of local dynamics. Brown (2005) highlights the "technical bias" in democracy assistance,

where efforts focus on superficial reforms—such as training journalists or judges—while neglecting structural political resistance to independent institutions. The conditionality of assistance, particularly during the 1990s in Zambia, illustrates how varying donor interests complicated reform implementation and undermined policy coherence (Rakner, 2003). Donor influence is further reinforced through project-based funding modalities, which often fail to align with national budgets and long-term priorities (Andersson et al., 2000). As UNESCO (2021) reports, fragmented project assistance can reduce recipient ownership and marginalize the role of domestic planning institutions. The preference for “targeting” approaches, driven by donor accountability needs, may also distort development priorities by favouring short-term, quantifiable outcomes over broader systemic change (Mkandawire, 2005).

The adaptation of national development policies to donor frameworks poses several systemic challenges that significantly affect both the sovereignty and effectiveness of recipient governments. First, prolonged reliance on foreign assistance tends to undermine domestic policy-making capacity, as governments become accustomed to external support rather than investing in mechanisms for local resource mobilization (Moyo, 2009). As Glennie (2008) argues, this dependency gradually erodes the incentives to develop autonomous fiscal and administrative institutions, ultimately weakening state capacity. Second, the predominance of project-based assistance structures often leads to a form of short-termism in development planning (Fowler, 2000). Funding is frequently tied to predefined deliverables and limited timeframes, encouraging implementers to focus on measurable, short-term outputs rather than long-term systemic transformation (UNESCO, 2021). According to Easterly (2010), such an approach neglects structural inequalities and fails to build institutional resilience, thereby limiting the sustainability of development interventions. Third, policy instability emerges as a further consequence of donor-driven agendas as national strategies are frequently adjusted to reflect shifting donor priorities, often resulting in fragmented planning and undermining the coherence and continuity of development policies (Thomas et. al., 2014). As Whitfield (2009) highlights, this instability can disrupt local ownership and long-term strategic vision, making it difficult for recipient governments to formulate and implement comprehensive development trajectories aligned with their domestic priorities. Despite these constraints, national actors exhibit considerable agency in adapting donor demands to local realities. The actor-oriented approach (Long, 2001) underscores that recipient governments and

organizations actively reinterpret donor policies, selectively adopt reforms, and negotiate terms that align with their own interests.

Therefore, the recipient perspective is essential for evaluating the real impacts of foreign assistance and for ensuring that development initiatives are contextually appropriate and locally owned. While modernization theorists like Rostow (1960) view development assistance as a catalyst for progress, post-development scholars challenge this narrative (Lie, 2008). This critique is particularly relevant for the NGO sector, where “donor capture” can lead to programming that reflects donor priorities rather than community needs (Todaro & Smith, 2020). Fowler (2000) warns that growing dependence on tax-based donor funds may compromise NGO accountability to their local constituencies and weaken their civic roots. In conclusion, the perspectives of recipients provide critical insights into the complex power dynamics of foreign assistance. Understanding how national governments, NGOs, and civil society navigate donor conditionalities, funding mechanisms, and institutional reforms helps reveal both the possibilities and limitations of development assistance. As development cooperation continues to evolve, centering recipient agency and ownership will be crucial for fostering sustainable, equitable, and context-sensitive outcomes.

In context of Long (2001), development is not only a matter of macroeconomic planning or institutional aid flows, but a lived and interpreted reality shaped by those directly involved. By integrating these perspectives, this thesis recognizes that development assistance often carries embedded power relations, discursive constructions, and unintended consequences that only become visible when examined from the bottom up. These theoretical perspectives, particularly the emphasis on individual agency, discursive framing (Lie, 2015), and the political economy of assistance (Brown, 1995), collectively provide a framework for analysing how recipients engage with, adapt to, and at times internalize or resist externally driven development interventions. Therefore, it allows us to interrogate the daily practices, meanings, and contradictions embedded in donor-driven initiatives

4 METHODOLOGIES

This chapter outlines the methodological framework employed in this research, detailing the approach used to investigate the dependency of participants in development projects in Zambia on development assistance. The study adopts a qualitative research design, emphasizing an ethnographic approach to gain in-depth insights into the experiences, motivations, and challenges faced by various actors. The choice of this methodology is based on the need to explore the perspectives of individuals directly engaged in foreign-funded projects and to understand how they navigate their reliance on external resources.

The research draws from ethnographic approach mainly based on semi-structured interviews conducted with representatives from various development projects and cooperatives operating in Zambia. This approach allows for flexibility in data collection, ensuring that key themes are addressed while also providing space for informants to elaborate on their perspectives around topics, that were prepared by the researcher in advance with the possibility to ask different questions, as the semi-structured interviews let things run their own course (Galletta, 2013; Soukup, 2017). Furthermore, focus groups were employed as an additional method, enabling participants to elaborate on each other's ideas and contribute to collective discussions, bringing more insights into the narrative of discussed topic (Hennink, 2014). Additionally, participant observation, that help with understanding of an environment and document analysis complement the primary data, offering a broader contextual understanding of the projects' role in development (Prasad, 2005).

Although ethnography is challenging to define precisely, it remains one of the most effective tools for gaining in-depth knowledge and understanding of everyday life within the research environment. As an empirical research method, it requires the researcher to spend a significant amount of time in the studied setting, allowing for direct engagement with participants in development projects and their lived experiences (O'Reilly, 2011). This approach played a crucial role in shaping the research focus of this study. Initially, the researcher intended to explore a broader topic but gradually shifted towards understanding specific aspects of informants' lives. Through semi-structured interviews, focus groups, and informal conversations—many of which were not originally intended for data collection—valuable insights were gathered across various sectors. These interactions ultimately revealed a recurring narrative: the request for external support.

Recognizing this pattern led to a reformulation of the research questions, refining the study's focus to its current form.

This chapter further explains the selection criteria for informants, the interview process, and the methods used for data analysis. Ethical considerations, including informed consent, confidentiality and positionality of the author are also discussed to ensure the integrity of the research. By employing an ethnographic perspective, this study seeks to provide a comprehensive and nuanced analysis of how development assistance influences operations and decision-making processes in Zambia.

4.1 Data Collection

The data for this research were collected during an academic field trip to Zambia in the autumn of 2024 and as part of broader research that was covering more than one topic. As qualitative research is not about representative sample of informants, the study continued in ethnographic approach and employed a purposive sampling method and theoretical sampling method to ensure a diverse range of informants (O'Reilly, 2011). Purposive sampling was initially designed based on the primary research topics—farmers were selected to explore the impact of climate change, while women were chosen to examine their position in society. As the study progressed, theoretical sampling was implemented, as the researcher began developing an assumption on dependency on foreign assistance. This approach proved more suitable, aligning with the definition provided O'Reilly (2011, p.44) which states that “*a sample is generated for the purpose of generating and refining theory: people, settings, times, and situations are included because of their relevance for the developing theoretical explanations and as a means of checking for contradictory cases that delimit the theory*”.

The research was structured around the following key research questions: *What motivations do diverse actors within development projects in Zambia have to participate in development projects? What strategies do diverse actors within development projects in Zambia employ to secure external support? What forms of development assistance are most commonly sought by NGOs?* These questions served as the foundation for semi-structured interviews and focus groups conducted with various stakeholders. In total, there were four focus groups and twenty-seven individual interviews. The interviews covered a broad range of topics, tailored to the specific backgrounds of the informants.

Farmers were interviewed regarding the impact of environmental changes on their livelihoods, women from cooperatives were asked about their social and economic positions, regional managers discussed their roles within development projects, and representatives from other NGOs reflected on the role of tourism in the sector (see all questions sets in Annexes). While the core interview questions remained consistent, they were adjusted as necessary based on the flow of conversation. The complete set of interview questions is included in the appendix. Each interview concluded with the question: *Is there anything else you would like to mention before we finish this interview?* This open-ended inquiry created an opportunity for informants to express their perspectives on external support, often leading to direct or indirect requests for assistance.

Following data collection, responses were categorized based on the types of external support requested, and strategies employed to secure such support, and subsequently analysed using thematic analysis, which *"allows each issue to be analyzed in depth and the relationships between issues to be identified, to build an understanding of the research issues from the perspective of study participants."* Hennink (2014, p. 90)

The selection of informants was intentionally designed to ensure diversity within the sample. All interviews were conducted in person and recorded to ensure accuracy. Additionally, the researcher took detailed notes throughout the interviews, allowing for the refinement of questions and the inclusion of emerging topics. These notes were preserved as they provided valuable insights into the course of discussions and initial impressions, which were later utilized in the evaluation of the data. The duration of the interviews varied from 15 to 90 minutes, with an average duration of 35 minutes. The format of the interviews was flexible, sometimes involving two interviewers engaging with a single informant, while in other cases, one interviewer interacted with multiple participants in development project. The interviews were conducted primarily in English, with the occasional assistance of translators when required.

4.2 Informants

The research sample consisted of 37 informants with a gender distribution of 11 males and 26 females. Informants were accessed through various organizations, including Booma Women Cooperative from south Zambia, Conservation and Tourism Society (CATS) from Livingstone, south Zambia, New Renato Community Society (NRCS) from

Kashitu, central Zambia, project Integrated Farming III from western Zambia, where donor is CzechAid and the project is implemented by Mendel University, Destination Livingstone Initiative, south Zambia and independent farmers from all above mentioned regions. Additionally, informants were affiliated with other organizations, such as People in Need (PIN), Caritas, BioCarbon Partners (BCP), local community and governmental projects. The specific organization is not mentioned when interpreting data to ensure the anonymity of informants. The age range of the informants spanned from 18 to 77 years old, concrete age is not stated with informants to protect their anonymity. Their length of involvement in respective organizations varied, with some informants having only recently joined, while others had participated for several years. Regarding livelihoods, informants engaged in diverse economic activities, including small-scale and subsistence farming, cooperative-based agriculture, tourism-related work, and NGO-driven community initiatives. Livelihoods shown in Table 1 are only for informative value, based on a description of livelihoods by informants themselves, and don't represent informants' real positions within development projects. The variety in livelihoods contributed to a broader understanding of the ways in which different groups perceive and interact with foreign assistance and development support. For more fluent interpretation of results informants were randomly named using common Zambian names to secure anonymity and prevent recognition of informants.

Name	Livelihood	Gender	Region
Thandiwe	Farmer	Female	South
Luyando	Housekeeper	Female	South
Natasha	Farmer	Female	South
Chipo	Farmer	Female	South
Grace	Farmer	Female	South
Chimwemwe	Farmer	Female	South
Bupe	Shop owner, Farmer	Female	South
Monde	Teacher, Volunteer	Female	South
Tisa	Teacher, Volunteer	Female	South
Misozi	Manager	Female	South
Mwansa	Volunteer	Male	South
Tamara	Manager	Female	South
Chanda	Farmer	Male	West
Mwaka	Farmer	Female	West

Bwalya	Farmer	Male	West
Lackson	Farmer	Male	West
Agnes	Farmer	Female	West
Mulenga	Farmer	Male	West
Kelvin	Farmer	Male	West
Beauty	Farmer	Female	West
Mumba	Farmer	Male	West
Brighton	Manager	Male	West
Chileshe	Manager	Male	West
Thokozile	Manager, Farmer	Female	West
Felistus	Beekeeper	Female	Central
Chibesa	Beekeeper, Farmer	Female	Central
Brenda	Beekeeper	Female	Central
Tamara	Beekeeper, Farmer	Female	Central
Mable	Beekeeper	Female	Central
Miriam	Beekeeper	Female	Central
Prisca	Tailor	Female	Central
Judy	Tailor	Female	Central
Matildah	Tailor	Female	Central
Tionge	Tailor	Female	Central
Renatha	Tailor	Female	Central
Mutinta	Manager	Male	Central
Kondwani	Manager	Male	Central

Figure 1: Informants

Source: Author's work

Informants in this study were located across multiple regions within Zambia, specifically Mongu, Kashitu, and Livingstone. These locations were selected to provide a diverse socio-economic and environmental context, allowing for a more comprehensive analysis of the role of foreign assistance and NGO involvement. Mongu, the capital of Western Province, serves as a key centre for agriculture and trade. The region is characterized by seasonal flooding due to its proximity to the Zambezi River, which significantly impacts farming cycles and food security. Many NGOs operate in Mongu, focusing on agricultural development, climate resilience, and rural livelihoods (Mongu district council, 2024). Kashitu, located in Central Province, represents a rural setting where the local economy is predominantly dependent on subsistence farming and cooperative-based agriculture. The area faces significant obstacles, including soil degradation, limited access to markets, and climate variability, which directly affect local farmers' ability to sustain their

livelihoods (Kapiri Mposhi Town Council, 2023). Livingstone, situated in Southern Province, serves as Zambia's primary tourism hub due to its proximity to Victoria Falls. While the tourism sector provides employment opportunities, many local communities remain reliant on small-scale farming and informal economic activities. NGOs operating in the region focus on community development, conservation initiatives, and women's empowerment, often seeking external funding to sustain these programs. Additionally, the region's exposure to international visitors has influenced the nature of development assistance requests, with a greater emphasis on projects related to eco-tourism and cultural heritage preservation (Livingstone City Council, 2023). This geographical diversity enabled the study to examine the role of foreign assistance and NGO interventions across different economic and environmental landscapes, allowing for a nuanced understanding of how assistance dependency manifests in rural agricultural communities, flood-prone areas, and tourism-driven economies.

4.3 Limits of research

Several limitations must be acknowledged in this study. One of the primary constraints was the language barrier, as some informants had limited proficiency in English, necessitating frequent translations. This reliance on translation may have influenced the accuracy and nuance of responses. Additionally, certain informants struggled to fully grasp the research topic, requiring the interviewer to repeat or rephrase questions to ensure clarity. Another limitation that must be acknowledged concerns the data collection process, which was conducted by multiple researchers across various regions and organizations. While this collaborative approach enriched the dataset by incorporating diverse perspectives and field experiences, it also introduced a degree of variation in interviewing style, emphasis, and follow-up questioning, which may have influenced the depth and comparability of the responses. Differences in interpretation, language use, or contextual knowledge between interviewers could have subtly shaped how informants articulated their views, and how their answers were later analysed. Although efforts were made to standardize the interview guide and training of interviewers, this variability represents a potential source of bias that must be considered when interpreting the findings.

Another significant limitation is the non-generalizability of the findings. The study presents examples drawn from various regions and sectors within Zambia; however, these insights cannot be universally applied to the entire development sector, as the research was not initially designed for generalization (O'Reilly, 2011). Furthermore, the positionality of the researcher as an academic from the Czech Republic may have influenced the responses, as some participants in development may have viewed the interview as an opportunity to advocate for additional support. While qualitative research methods allowed for a deeper understanding of the mechanisms through which informants secure development assistance, in the future research incorporating mixed-method approaches could provide a more comprehensive perspective.

A potential for bias also arises from the involvement of some informants in projects supported or implemented by Mendel University, the researcher's home institution. This affiliation may have led informants to perceive the researcher as a potential benefactor, influencing their responses toward requests for continued institutional support rather than providing neutral insights. However, this risk was mitigated by the researcher's explicit clarification at the beginning of each interview, emphasizing the independent nature of the study and her lack of direct involvement in specific projects. Finally, the personal experiences and subjective perspectives of informants inevitably influenced their answers, which may have introduced an additional layer of bias into the findings.

4.4 Ethics

Ethical integrity was upheld throughout the research process. Each interview began with an explanation of the study's purpose, ensuring that informants understood the nature and objectives of the research. Informants were explicitly informed of their right to terminate the interview at any time without providing a reason. Given potential limitations in literacy or comprehension of written consent forms in English, informed consent was obtained verbally, with many informants also with transplanation to their mother tongue (Hennink, 2014). Efforts were made to ensure a respectful and culturally appropriate interview environment, with careful consideration given to language use, setting, and the interviewer's approach. Additionally, informants were assured of their anonymity, and confidentiality was strictly maintained throughout the research process.

It is essential to critically reflect on the researcher's positionality and how it may have influenced the research process, particularly in the context of development studies. As a woman affiliated with a European university, conducting interviews with representatives of Zambian development projects, researcher's presence inevitably carried social, cultural, and historical implications. This positionality may have shaped the power dynamics during data collection, influencing how informants perceived me, the degree of openness they displayed, or the type of narratives they chose to emphasize. In some cases, informants might have tailored their responses to align with what they assumed were the expectations of a European academic, potentially reinforcing donor-recipient tropes or highlighting perceived success stories. In other cases, the identity of research as an outsider may have limited access to more critical or sensitive perspectives, particularly concerning local frustrations with donor practices or internal organizational challenges. Furthermore, researcher's background, academic training, and the lens through which development cooperation is interpreted are grounded in a particular epistemological and cultural framework. This inevitably affects the interpretation and representation of the data, even when efforts are made to centre local voices and experiences. While steps were taken to mitigate these effects, such as using semi-structured interviews that allowed respondents to lead the conversation, and engaging in reflexive notetaking throughout the research process, these limitations cannot be entirely eliminated. Recognizing this positionality does not invalidate the research but rather enhances its transparency. It underlines the importance of ongoing reflexivity, critical self-awareness, and a commitment to ethical and respectful engagement in cross-cultural research contexts.

5 RESULTS

This chapter presents the key findings of the research, which aimed to explore the motivations, expectations, and strategies of local actors involved in development projects supported by foreign assistance. The results are based on qualitative interviews conducted with representatives of community-based organisations, non-governmental initiatives, and local institutions, and in person observations before, during and after interviews and during the stay. Each section is framed by existing academic literature on development assistance, development dependency, and local agency, which provides a theoretical foundation for interpreting the empirical data. The informants' statements are subsequently analysed in relation to these theoretical frameworks. The chapter is structured into three main sections: motivations for engaging with development assistance and development projects, the forms of assistance requested, and strategies used by recipients to attract and retain donor support. These themes were identified through a thematic analysis of the data and reflect both individual and organisational perspectives on foreign support. The chapter aims not only to document local experiences with development assistance but also to critically assess the dynamics of dependency, autonomy, and negotiation present in assistance relationships.

5.1 Motivations of Participants in Development Projects

To understand the motivations of assistance recipients, it is essential to comprehend their perspectives on development assistance and the reasons for their participation in development projects (Long, 2001). The motivations that led informants to participate in foreign development projects were shaped by a number of factors. Analysis of their responses shows that these factors often overlap and combine economic, social, and educational expectations. Overall, the common motivation was to improve one's own or one's family's economic situation. Informants hoped that the project would enable them to earn an income or increase their current income, either through the provision of funds or through training that would enable them to find employment or start a small business. Economic motivations described by Todaro and Smith (2020) align with highlighted income improvement and the creation of income opportunities as key individual incentives for participation in development processes. At the individual level, participants in development projects expressed aspirations related to self-improvement, entrepreneurship, and family welfare. Frequently articulated motivations was the desire

to establish or improve small businesses to reach economic independence or growth. For instance, Thandiwe, a farmer who has participated in the development project for two years, articulated her goals with clarity: *"I bought a bag of cement, one by one, and built the shop with my husband, now I need money to buy food to sell."* Her engagement in the cooperative has been, as she put it, *"the only way how to fulfil my dreams."* (Thandiwe, 27.09.2024, South region) She perceives her involvement in the project as a strategic opportunity for personal and familial development. Her vision is not unique. Another informant, Luyando, whose livelihoods were described as housekeeping and cooking, stated that she would like to sell clothes and have her own business. In Zambia, the informal sector constitutes a vital part of the economy, employing around 90% of the workforce, with over one million micro and small informal enterprises, mainly in agriculture and retail, operating alongside only about 30,000 formal MSMEs (Shah, 2012). Despite its economic significance, most informal businesses generate very low revenues and remain outside the tax system, leading to divided governmental views, some seeing the sector as unproductive, while others, including the Ministry of Small and Medium Enterprise Development, advocate for its strategic support and gradual integration into the formal economy (MSMED, 2023). Although formalization brings improved access to services and finance, it also exposes businesses to bureaucratic burdens and corruption, highlighting the need for nuanced policy approaches that balance regulation with capacity-building (Shah, 2012). Additionally, for individuals with children, motivations often reflected family-centred needs, such as the desire to afford school uniforms or textbooks. Some of the informants perceived the assistance as a means to purchase food during times of shortage and to obtain non-essential goods for their families. Here, the expectation of assistance was grounded in its potential to alleviate daily household burdens. Interestingly, some female informants emphasized how participation in donor-supported initiatives allowed them to exercise a form of agency that was otherwise limited in their socio-economic context. Women often associated their engagement with empowerment and improved status within the household. Development assistance programs can strengthen individual capabilities, particularly among marginalized groups, even if the broader structural inequalities persist (Riddell, 2008).

From a community-level perspective, assistance is often seen as the only realistic avenue for structural improvement, especially in areas where state presence is weak or

underfunded (World Bank Group, 2022). One farmer Chanda, who is one of the oldest informants and currently cooperates with multiple assistance providers, highlighted the dual benefit of knowledge transfer and material support: *“We wanted you people, Mendelu people, to be with us for quite a number of years. So, if you leave us, you educated us more.”* (Chanda, 08.10.2024, West region) He continued by acknowledging the material support that accompanied the partnership, specifically mentioning the provision of pumps essential for water supply, which enabled him to increase his income by selling a greater number of plants. Informants commonly referred to the Integrated Farming III project as the 'Mendelu project', although Mendel University serves solely as the implementing partner in the region. From a development perspective, this suggests that recipients and beneficiaries of development assistance often do not identify with the broader goals and objectives of such projects, but rather focus on the visible provider, whom they can name, and the tangible assistance delivered. Other participants in development projects also recalled past assistance experiences and the promises made by donors, such as Felistus, who works in a group of beekeepers, that produces honey, and reflected on support from German donors: *“They encouraged us that they are going to buy small quantity but pay a lot of money and they will find us a market, where to sell.”* (Felistus, 17.10.2024, Central region) This production was initiated thanks to donor support, which provided the community with free technical assistance and education, in response to the impacts of climate change and the decline in agricultural production. According to available sources, climate change significantly affects agricultural production in Zambia through increasingly unpredictable and adverse weather conditions, particularly rainfall patterns and periods of drought have historically led to severe consequences (Andersson et al, 2000). The variability of rainfall consistently reduces agricultural growth by approximately one percentage point annually, causes recurring crop failures, and threatens food security, while water shortages further endanger Zambia's unique natural resources that are essential for the tourism sector (Foster & Dominguez, 2010). In contexts of high uncertainty, participation can also serve as a risk mitigation strategy, as suggested by Collier (2007). This is especially relevant in cases where informants, such as Natasha, who already owns a small business and participates in the project for nearly two years, articulated hopes for additional tools or machines to further develop their activities.

Whereas some respondents emphasized the benefits of development assistance as such, others described distinct motivations for becoming involved in the projects through which the assistance was delivered. For some informants the motivation to join a development project was shaped by external pressures, including peer influence or village-level expectations. Some informants admitted that they joined simply because “everyone in the village joined” or because “they told me it would be good.” Luyando, who had previously only managed the household and had no income-generating activity, stated: *“I wanted to join women, because I didn’t do anything at home.”* (Luyando, 27.09.2024, South region) As education and empowerment were among the benefits women gained after joining the cooperative, they shared this information with many members of the community. This approach was confirmed also by Chipso, who described her life only with one word, which was suffering, and on contrary of joining the cooperative she said: *“[It] is good to share with other women...”* (Chipso, 27.09.2024, South region) In these cases, participation was more about aligning with existing social norms than about strategic planning or personal ambition. When the project in which Luyando and Chipso participated began, it operated like a snowball effect, with women meeting, discussing potential benefits, and encouraging other women to join.

Nonetheless, the motivations are not always purely based on actual need or strategic interest. In some cases, a kind of learned dependency was observed, as one independent farmer Thokozile critically explained:

“People in Lusaka, they lie when applying for grants. They know that they can tell the donor or funder what he wants to hear. If I write the proposal myself, they think it is rubbish.” (Thokozile, 12.10.2024, West region)

Then she continued with addressing the issues how some grant applicants use misleading photos of non-existing farms. Despite the widespread deployment of development assistance projects across sectors such as agriculture and infrastructure in Zambia, available sources highlight a wide array of implementation challenges, including weak administration and management, dependence on counterpart funds, unclear distribution of responsibilities between donors and recipients, fragmented development assistance architecture, limited stakeholder involvement (IFAD, 2018), and poor absorptive capacity, all of which can severely hinder project outcomes and long-term sustainability (Andersson et al, 2000). While the notion of fraud is not explicitly addressed, many of

the identified problems in Zambia create an environment in which inefficiencies and potential misuse of funds may occur.

In some cases, the motivation to join projects was based on direct practical advantages. For example, Monde, a participant in development project working with the NGO, explained how the organization offered job opportunities to earn extra income, which is much needed, as she works in the public sector as a nurse. Another volunteer, Tisa, who studied biology at university and inherited a passion for wildlife conservation from her father, now works for the same NGO. Wildlife conservation in Zambia is of critical importance not only for safeguarding biodiversity and sustaining the ecological integrity of national parks and game management areas, which together cover 30% of the country's land, but also because it plays a pivotal role in enhancing rural livelihoods through non-agricultural income opportunities such as tourism and safari hunting, despite being accompanied by significant challenges, including unequal distribution of benefits, persistent human-wildlife conflicts, and weak transparency in revenue-sharing mechanisms, that must be addressed to ensure the long-term sustainability and equity of conservation-driven development (Richardson et al., 2012). These testimonies reflect how assistance projects can offer both economic opportunities and personal fulfilment, aligning with the broader observation by Easterly (2010) that individuals often engage with development assistance because it has become normalized as the default channel for change. However, some individuals expressed interest in joining a project but were constrained by logistical or personal factors. One independent farmer Agnes stated: *“I am very interested to join [an] organization. But I don’t stay here. I go to Limulunga and then I come back. I can’t join Mendelu project because of my business.”* (Agnes, 07.10.2024, West region) She sells charcoal and must move from place to place according to the season, and thus she doesn’t fulfil the requirements set by the development projects in the region. However, according to Brown (2005) the effectiveness of assistance, including grants, remains contested, as studies suggest that without an enabling political environment, assistance is often insufficient in promoting economic growth or sustaining political reforms, and Zambia exemplifies these mixed outcomes; further complications arise from the conditionalities attached to development assistance, both political and economic, which have shown only limited success in encouraging democratic transformation, with some evidence even pointing to a weak inverse correlation between

political liberalization and conditionality, and to potentially adverse consequences of economically driven conditions such as privatization (Glennie, 2008).

The most differentiated perspective was found among individuals who manage or coordinate projects. Unlike local informants, their involvement was professionalized and financially compensated. One informant, Tamara, originally from Ireland, who studied and worked in Europe before moving to Zambia to manage development projects, now runs an NGO that promotes sustainable tourism in southern Zambia, observed a lack of initiative among local project participants:

“There was none from local NGOs who had any experience from proposal writing. I used to look for grants and think if there was anyone who it would help. Then I posted it on social media if anyone wants to create a project. None applied, because they have got used to being just given by donor and not look for their own money.” (Tamara, 01.10.2024, South region)

These views illustrate how, over time, a culture of expectation can emerge, in which actors position themselves not as co-creators of change but as recipients of predetermined benefits (Easterly, 2010; Moyo, 2009). However, the interviews with another project managers suggest that dependency is not uniform. As one manager Brighton noted: *“Farmers don’t complain, they are able to have more income by selling fish, there is still something coming to their pocket.” (Brighton, 11.10.2024, West region)* Chilese, who is in daily contact with local farmers impacted by the project elaborated on the idea of dependency and said:

“There are some [farmers] who are dependent, some are fine, some are self-sufficient. By giving them the knowledge, they feel that Mendelu is with us... There is one group, which has no idea how they will continue if we leave. But the other group, they know they will be able to continue even without material support from us.” (Chilese, 08.10.2024, West region)

These differences in perception, motivation, and capacity suggest that while development assistance may serve as an initial incentive, long-term transformation depends heavily on whether recipients transition from passive beneficiaries to empowered agents of their own development. The varying motivations observed in this study underscore the importance of designing assistance programs that respond to the complexity of local agency, rather than assuming uniformity in aspiration or capacity. In summary can be said that

informants' motivations for seeking development assistance were individual growth and increased incomes, possible empowerment and education, and personal beliefs, while some joined the project based on a passive approach but see possible development by securing more assistance.

5.2 Form of Development Assistance

The interviews conducted with project participants revealed valuable insights into the nature of development assistance that is most frequently requested by local actors. Contrary to the widespread assumption that financial assistance is the most sought-after form of support, informants emphasized practical and tangible needs, such as the acquisition of agricultural equipment, access to marketing channels, and capacity building. These preferences show assistance recipients tend to value concrete, immediate outcomes over abstract, long-term planning (Riddell, 2008). The requests articulated by informants often reflected their direct experience with specific challenges. For instance, some participants from the women's group identified the need for machinery to increase their production capacity and expand their market reach. One of the members, Natasha, explained: *"Maybe you help us to have another machine to press more oil. I can only apply a grant that we have another machine. Maybe you can help us from Czech Republic."* (Natasha, 27.09.2024, South region) This women's group is currently working with a single machine. The earnings are divided among the participants who contributed during a particular week or month, but no funds are saved for the potential purchase of another machine. Members of the group are expecting the donor to provide additional machines. This quote highlights a desire for specific physical tools rather than financial resources in general. Another informant, Thandiwe, underscored the importance of support with market access: *"May you help us with this what we are doing here? In case of marketing, help us, with selling our products, not only in Zambia but other countries too."* (Thandiwe, 27.09.2024, South region) Both statements reflect a direct link between economic survival and concrete tools or services. The emphasis is not on receiving funds to use at will, but rather on acquiring means that support production and sustainability. In similar terms, another woman from the same project remarked that it would be beneficial if we, as researchers, assisted them in selling more, as they need funds to purchase another machine. Statements like this suggest that some women made efforts to secure assistance with sales in order to continue their development and independently purchase additional

machinery. Although these requests remained focused on physical resources, the informants did not elaborate on the logistics or sustainability of such support. The need for support was also acknowledged by informant Grace, who described her life as miserable due to a lack of assistance. Her brief but poignant mention of support served as a plea for the project to help her sell more items. Such open-ended appeals, though grounded in real needs, often lack specificity regarding responsibility or local capacity, which Moyo (2009) interprets as a symptom of assistance as a normalized response to development needs.

The desire for practical input was further reiterated by farmers working with development projects. Bwalya, a farmer from western part of Zambia, noted the prohibitive cost of farming essentials:

“We need pesticides and sprayers. We really need the chemicals. The chemicals are available in the agroshops, but I don’t have the financial power. That is why I approached the office, and they did promise me.”
(Bwalya, 07.10.2024, West region)

After a lengthy discussion about the need for pesticides, it became clear that no such promise had been made. However, Bwalya believed that if he mentioned this need on record, it would increase his chances of receiving support. Climate change is increasingly affecting agriculture in Zambia, with smallholder farmers being particularly vulnerable due to their dependence on rain-fed production and limited adaptive capacity. According to available data, southern and western regions of Zambia are projected to experience a decline in rainfall by 3 to 4 percentage points on average by 2050, with worst-case scenarios reaching up to 20–30 percentage points, while temperatures across the country could rise, significantly impacting crop yields, especially maize (Ngoma et al., 2021). In some cases, small capital investments such as pesticides or irrigation pumps can significantly enhance productivity and mitigate vulnerability. Another farmer, Lackson, made the connection between climate change and the need for technical solutions: *“Maybe if I had a pond or a pump, I could deal with the climate change more.”* (Lackson, 09.10.2024, West region) Here, environmental concerns are tightly linked with access to appropriate technology, an issue also emphasized in another interview, when Mulenga, a farmer who has been farming since young age said that during the time of climate change, he required a water pump or other irrigation system, to support the households. More

informants addressed the same issue of climate change and the need of external support to overcome its impacts. These insights suggest that while climate change is understood as a pressing problem, it is rarely addressed through systemic adaptation but rather through one-off technical fixes. Such expectations reflect the dominance of externally driven models of development assistance, where tools and devices are offered as the most visible forms of intervention.

Despite the general openness to receiving help, not all informants expressed a wish for additional assistance. One farmer, Agnes, who is currently not involved in any project, for instance, simply stated that there was nothing she would add and did not attempt to secure any assistance throughout the interview. While such a statement may suggest self-reliance, it could also reflect disillusionment with assistance effectiveness or previous experiences of unmet promises. In contrast, other informants described assistance as a potential pathway to economic betterment. One of them was Kelvin, who said: *“I appeal to Mendelu, I would like to have more species of trees, so I can earn more money from selling fruit.”* (Kelvin, 07.10.2024, West region) Here, assistance is perceived not as an end in itself, but as a step towards entrepreneurial activity. In Zambia, the sale of fruit is part of the broader fresh fruit and vegetable sector, which plays a vital role in rural livelihoods and food distribution, although its scale and benefits vary depending on regional and socio-economic conditions. According to available data, only a small share of smallholder farmers engages in selling horticultural produce such as fruit, despite bananas being the most significant fruit crop, which suggests that fruit sales remain relatively limited in comparison to vegetable sales among rural producers (Hichaambwa & Tschirley, 2006). Similarly, one independent actor Thokozile, who is a manager of her project connected assistance with fundraising potential: *“Financially we are really down. [We tried] Some fundraising. My friends in America, they wanted to help me, but in last years we didn’t do any fundraising.”* (Thokozile, 12.10.2024, West region) Her farm does not have any major donors and is difficult to access, as it is located in a remote area of Zambia; however, it helps the local community address deforestation and the consequences of climate change. NGOs in Zambia rely on a variety of funding sources, including donor support, partnerships with the government, and emerging community-based and microfinance initiatives. Donor support has significantly influenced the development of civil society in Zambia, not only by providing financial resources but also by enabling the emergence of broad-based coalitions that include NGOs, religious

organizations, and political actors, one prominent example of such a donor is The Oasis Forum, which was established with donor backing and successfully mobilized various civil society stakeholders to advocate for democratic reforms and resist constitutional amendments aimed at extending presidential powers (UNU-WIDER, 2013). Deforestation, as Thokozile mentioned, in Zambia is a multifaceted issue driven by population growth, demand for agricultural land, and reliance on wood for fuel, which contributes to environmental degradation and intensifies rural poverty. In one illustrative scenario, rural families are warned against cutting down remaining trees or cultivating marginal land, yet the urgent need for basic survival, particularly the collection of firewood for cooking, continues to drive deforestation, leading to soil erosion, declining crop yields, and increasing vulnerability to droughts (Todaro and Smith, 2020). Notably, support in the form of knowledge and capacity building was also valued by some informants. One of the women Grace explicitly thanked the researchers for their involvement, and discussions that she perceived as teaching opportunities. Education in Zambia takes place both within the formal school system and through various informal channels, including community-based initiatives, skills training programmes, and on-the-job learning, which together contribute to lifelong learning and address diverse socio-economic needs. Formal education is supported by national assessment frameworks and reform programmes (MESVTEE, 2014), while informal learning occurs through NGO-led vocational training, agricultural extension services, and community-level knowledge sharing, particularly in contexts such as conflict mitigation with wildlife or skill acquisition in the informal sector (Richardson et al., 2012). Another member of a community-based project, Mwansa, highlighted the importance of learning and mutual exchange:

“When you go back, you can share with friends, family, with your country. Comment on what we are doing. Share some ideas, to learn more, to invite us to come. Maybe more projects and more collaborations.” (Mwansa, 29.09.2024, South region)

An informant Brenda from a honey cooperative similarly acknowledged the importance of skill transfer: *“There are some donors who come here to buy our honey. They buy it, then process it, pack it and then sell it. They should come and teach us how to process.” (Brenda, 29.09.2024, South region)* She was unable to elaborate further on this topic, as

she was not empowered to make decisions within the project or its logistics. Nevertheless, she was still able to acknowledge the work that donors do in her community. Rather than merely asking for new equipment or funding, this response signals a desire for deeper integration into the value chain, a development approach that builds independence rather than perpetuating reliance. Value chains are a relevant concept in Zambia, particularly within the agricultural sector, where they play a crucial role in the production and distribution of fresh fruits and vegetables, and their effectiveness depends on factors such as infrastructure, market access, and coordination among various actors. According to Thomas et al. (2014) the participation of smallholder farmers in horticultural value chains remains very low, despite the presence of initiatives like the Market Improvement and Innovation Facility, which aims to foster innovative business linkages between these farmers and other actors in the chain. The manager of beekeeping project, Mutinta, emphasized the role of various international partnerships: *“We have many many collaborators, they help us, they support us with their capacity.”* (Mutinta, 17.10.2024, Central region) This project has collaborated with several donors, including USAID, German donors, CzechAid, and many others, as Mutinta commented. Such collaborations suggest a more balanced model of cooperation, though these remain exceptions rather than the rule. Nonetheless, certain responses illustrated the internalization of the donor-recipient dynamic in its most simplified form, as when Luyando requested support by simply saying, 'We need support,' and another farmer, Agnes, who lives kilometres away, mentioned that she was looking forward to receiving assistance from the government. Further complexity is introduced by the role of intermediaries, such as local NGO managers. One such manager of an NGO in southern Zambia, Tamara, who is responsible for project proposals and is knowledgeable about a range of donors, explained the process through which external support is distributed:

“They can’t just rely on me if they want to grow their marketing. I keep getting some grants – from Czech embassy, Irish government supported us a little. Then I can support, for example, local NGO and other projects.” (Tamara, 01.10.2024, South region)

This quote confirms the crucial function of local gatekeepers in filtering and allocating assistance, a practice which can empower or constrain local actors depending on transparency and capacity. In parallel, some development projects have attempted to raise

awareness about the communal benefits of assistance, particularly through educational programs for children. A teacher Misozi involved in tourism education described this effort:

“Children know that tourism is good and brings benefit. Our community knows that tourism helps them to bring money. Our children know how they benefit. They know that it is not only about the rich people in the lodges and safaris. They know that it can bring them money for supplies, hygiene, toys, books.” (Misozi, 29.09.2024, South region)

This shift in public understanding may contribute to greater community engagement and accountability in assistance-related projects, reducing the risk of passive dependency. Community-based tourism in Zambia revolves around the sustainable use of natural resources, aiming to combine wildlife conservation with socio-economic benefits for rural populations, particularly those living in game management areas near national parks. This community-based tourism has been developed through co-management agreements between local communities and authorities like the Zambia Wildlife Authority, where Community Resource Boards participate in wildlife conservation and revenue sharing from hunting concessions and photographic safaris; however, evidence suggests that the distribution of benefits remains uneven and the effectiveness of such initiatives in reducing poverty is mixed (Richardson et al., 2012).

Finally, efforts to strengthen local autonomy were described by project managers, particularly those working with local farmers on daily bases. Brighton reflected on the gradual transition towards local ownership: *“I would say they wanted to rely on Mendelu, but we told them that the help is coming, but we need to prepare you. So now, the farmers are managing.” (Brighton, 11.10.2024, West region)* This illustrates a conscious strategy to reduce external dependency and build local capacity, a principle often highlighted in academic literature but rarely implemented in practice (Riddell, 2008; Collier, 2007).

To sum up this subchapter, interviews reveal a clear preference among local participants for tangible, practical forms of development assistance, such as agricultural tools, market access, and training, over unrestricted financial aid. These findings reflect Riddell’s (2008) and Easterly’s (2010) critiques of top-down planning, emphasizing instead recipients’ desire for actionable improvements that directly affect their livelihoods. However, the frequent reliance on external support, often expressed in vague or

generalized terms, supports Moyo's (2009) argument about structural aid dependency. Simultaneously, some participants expressed interest in learning opportunities, value chain inclusion, and community-based tourism, pointing to a broader awareness of sustainable development practices. Local intermediaries and project managers play a key role in shaping how assistance is accessed and utilized, with some efforts already aiming to strengthen local autonomy. Overall, the findings highlight the complex interplay between material needs, institutional support, and long-standing donor-recipient dynamics.

5.3 “I Will Tell You How You Can Support Us”: Strategies for Effective Assistance

During field research conducted in Zambia, it became evident that local actors do not approach the question of external assistance passively. Rather, they demonstrate an ability to strategically frame their needs in ways that correspond to what they perceive as donor priorities and preferences. While on the surface these interactions may appear to be simple appeals for assistance, a deeper analysis reveals complex patterns of narrative adaptation, strategic language, and embedded knowledge of development discourse. These patterns confirm the theoretical observations of Riddell (2008), who argues that assistance recipients often "learn" how to communicate with donors by internalizing their terminologies and expectations. In this sense, asking for assistance becomes a performative act, shaped by both the structural conditions of assistance dependency and the agency of local actors seeking to navigate them. Informants often articulated their requests in ways that directly mirrored development terminology, particularly using concepts such as “empowerment,” “sustainability,” or references to the Sustainable Development Goals. One farmer Mumba, who also serves as model farmer for other farmer in the regions and therefore may receive more training noted:

“Mendelu came and when I started to work with Mendelu, I had seen a lot of change. It is about empowerment. I generally appreciate Mendelu. Keep on, support my family.” (Mumba, 09.10.2024, West region)

This statement illustrates not only the internalization of donor language, but also its rearticulation to serve local priorities—here, continued material and symbolic engagement with a foreign partner. The strategic use of the term “empowerment” is

particularly notable, as it simultaneously connotes agency and need, enabling the speaker to position themselves as both capable and deserving of support. Another frequently used narrative strategy involved references to continuity and long-term partnership. The desire for sustainable engagement rather than one-time development assistance appeared repeatedly. In these situations, appeals to continuity are not merely logistical, but deeply moral; they emphasize commitment, reciprocity, and loyalty as currencies of partnership. Beyond language, local actors often framed their appeals through narratives of vulnerability. Participants in development projects described the environmental challenges they face, particularly those related to water shortages or climate change, and positioned these challenges as justifications for continued or expanded support. Lackson, a farmer whose livelihood primarily depends on selling maize and who lives in a region currently deeply affected by droughts stronger than usual, observed:

“I have serious water challenge. I don’t know if this is the right platform to talk about it but maybe these people can do something about it. Maybe if I talk about it Mendelu can do something about it.” (Lackson, 09.10.2024, West region)

The tentative framing (“maybe... if I talk about it...”) demonstrates an awareness of the fine line between asking and begging, between agency and helplessness. This kind of performativity could be criticised as it suggests persistent need to justify ones suffering to external agents risking entrenching assistance dependency, reducing complex socio-ecological issues to donor-friendly soundbites (Moyo, 2009). Yet these narratives were not always rooted in helplessness. On the contrary, informants displayed empowered dependency, a state in which local actors acknowledge their reliance on external support but attempt to channel it in ways that promote autonomy and long-term benefit (Todaro and Smith, 2020). Another local farmer, Mulenga, whose tree seedlings are being threatened by intense sun and prolonged periods without rain, commented: *“During this time of climate change that support requires a water pump or other irrigation system. To support the households.” (Mulenga, 08.10.2024, West region)* This statement frames perceive assistance not as a gift, but as an investment, one that would help communities adapt to environmental shocks and reduce future dependency. Strategic framing was also evident in how actors structured their requests as discrete “projects,” often borrowing logics and formats familiar to donors. Rather than articulating needs in abstract or

emotional terms, informants presented them as if responding to a call for proposals. Similarly, Kondwani, who leads projects in Central Province, assists with proposal writing and is responsible for searching for donors, noted:

“We have the nursery school and primary and secondary school, that is what we want to build. [...] We need a lot of partners in the project to train in beekeeping and tree planting. We are aligning with SDG, because it’s good. And we hoped to find some funder, who would help us to continue.”
(Kondwani, 17.10.2024, Central region)

This type of response demonstrates both familiarity with development discourse and a clear strategy to embed the local project within broader global frameworks such as the SDGs, which have become a form of symbolic capital in assistance negotiations (Todaro & Smith, 2020). Zambia incorporates the SDGs into its national development planning, particularly in sectors such as education, where progress indicators are used to monitor improvements and guide strategic policymaking. The presence of SDG 4 indicators in Zambia's statistical records, such as proficiency levels in reading and mathematics across different stages of schooling, along with the formulation of national development plans like the Seventh National Development Plan (2017–2021), suggests that Zambia aligns its educational strategies with the global SDG framework (UNESCO, 2021; Ngoma et al., 2021). Importantly, not all appeals were purely instrumental. Some informants invoked shared values, past collaborations, or moral obligation as a basis for continued support. These appeals were less transactional and more relational, suggesting that trust, memory, and symbolic continuity matter just as much as financial input. Mutinta, one of the most vocal community members and a local project manager, stated: *“Thank you for remembering us. We have always appreciated Mendelu and Czech. Come back as soon as possible.”* (Mutinta, 17.10.2024, Central region) In this case, the act of “remembering” carries symbolic weight, functioning as a measure of solidarity and respect. Some informants employed more indirect strategies, suggesting opportunities for partnership or exposure without making explicit requests. One informant, Thokozile, who is currently searching for new donors to improve her project and broaden its positive impact on the community, noted: *“I have given all the information. But a suggestion – more information goes out there, because we are trying to start a permaculture.”* (Thokozile, 12.10.2024, West region) This informant hoped to get more support to start a training program of

permaculture for other community members. Although the term permaculture is rarely mentioned explicitly in Zambian agricultural discourse, its principles, such as ecological sustainability, resource recycling, and integrated land use, are reflected in various locally promoted sustainable farming practices. While permaculture is referenced only once in the context of sustainable agricultural systems in Zambia, key elements of its approach, such as agroforestry with nitrogen-fixing trees, organic soil management through compost and green manures, and the reuse of agricultural waste in integrated production systems, are documented in several sources addressing ecological and conservation agriculture (Ng'andwe et al., 2016). Rather than asking for funding, the speaker suggests a form of visibility and informational support, subtly signalling openness to future collaboration. This could be seen as kind of entrepreneurial self-presentation (Moyo, 2009). However, the diversity of responses also revealed internal differences among local actors themselves. As Chilese, a manager in a region with many farmers affected by climate change, noted:

“We have different types of farmers. There are some, who are dependent, some are fine, some are self-sufficient. By giving them the knowledge, they feel that Mendelu is with us, and until it is, we will benefit from Mendelu. There is one group, which has no idea how they will continue, if we leave. But the other group, they know, that they will be able to continue even without material support from us.” (Chilese, 08.10.2024, West region)

This observation underscores the importance of avoiding overgeneralization. Within the same community, there exist different orientations toward assistance: some actors are prepared for post-assistance sustainability, while others remain embedded in cycles of expectation and reliance.

Ultimately, the act of asking for support in this context cannot be reduced to a single story. Rather, it reflects a dynamic interplay between structural conditions of underdevelopment, historical legacies of donor-recipient relations, and the everyday agency of individuals navigating them. As Riddell (2008) reminds us, assistance does not exist in a vacuum, it is mediated through language, power, and performativity. The informants in this study are not passive recipients, but strategic agents negotiating their place within a system shaped by external logics but rooted in local realities. Their appeals, whether direct or subtle, emotional or technical, demonstrate a deep awareness of the

expectations of donors and the rules of the development arena, even as they seek to transform it from within.

6 DISCUSSION

The findings of this research provide important insights into how local actors in Zambia perceive and engage with external development support. The analysis reveals a complex interplay between agency, adaptation, and dependency, and offers a nuanced understanding of motivations and strategies adopted by local stakeholders in their engagement with foreign actors.

The motivations expressed by the informants challenge simplistic dichotomies of assistance dependency versus self-reliance. Rather than demonstrating passivity or learned helplessness, local actors consistently framed their engagement with external actors as a strategic opportunity for capacity-building, long-term empowerment, and access to resources otherwise unavailable. These motivations align with what Todaro and Smith (2020) describe as the rational response of individuals in low-income contexts to maximize opportunities under constrained circumstances. The emphasis on education, training, and exposure to new methods suggests that informants perceive foreign partnerships as a pathway toward upward mobility and improved socio-economic status.

While informants expressed goals that resonate with developmental ideals, such as self-sufficiency, climate adaptation, and youth empowerment, their strategic use of donor language and framing of requests reveal a deep awareness of the performative dimensions of development assistance. This confirms Riddell's (2008) assertion that actors in recipient countries often learn to "speak the language of development assistance," adapting their narratives to meet the expectations of international donors. The frequent references to SDGs, sustainability, and empowerment among interviewees indicate not only internalization of development discourse but also a pragmatic orientation: the use of such language is a tool for gaining legitimacy and attention in a competitive donor landscape. This adaptation raises important questions about authenticity and instrumentalization in assistance relationships. Easterly (2010) critiques the technocratic nature of Western development assistance, arguing that it tends to prioritize form over substance and reward actors who best replicate donor logic. From this perspective, the strategic alignment of local actors with donor expectations may be less a sign of genuine partnership and more a reflection of systemic asymmetries in power and knowledge (Brown, 2005). The findings of this research partially support this view, as informants framed their needs in project-oriented language and highlighted their alignment with

international frameworks, often without fully interrogating the implications or sustainability of such approaches. The presence of strategic behaviour does not necessarily indicate manipulation or dependency. On the contrary, it can be understood as a form of adaptive agency. As Moyo (2009) argues, the core problem with foreign assistance lies not in the willingness of local actors to seek support, but in the structural conditions that encourage permanent reliance rather than transitional assistance. In the Zambian context, informants articulated a desire for long-term collaboration, not continuous handouts. Their appeals were often framed in terms of partnership, shared history, and mutual respect. This suggests that what is perceived externally as “assistance-seeking” may internally be understood as a moral economy of reciprocity and solidarity.

The empirical data also reveal significant disparities in how different community members understand sustainability and prepare for the potential withdrawal of external support. While some actors expressed confidence in their ability to continue independently, others acknowledged a strong dependence on external inputs and guidance. As such, development actors must resist one-size-fits-all solutions and instead tailor support mechanisms to varying levels of preparedness and autonomy among local stakeholders (Todaro and Smith, 2020). Furthermore, the data point to the symbolic role of foreign engagement in community identity and local prestige. Informants frequently referred to the visibility, status, and recognition associated with their collaborations. For some, the presence of foreign actors validated their efforts and increased their credibility within the local or regional context. This symbolic economy of development assistance, where being associated with external institutions confers status and potential access to resources, has been well-documented in development literature (Riddell, 2008; Moyo, 2009). It also raises ethical questions for donors regarding the unintended social hierarchies that such relationships may reinforce. Another notable aspect of the findings is the moral framing of development assistance requests. Some informants appealed not only to utility or outcomes but also to values such as trust, loyalty, and shared memory. These appeals are not easily quantifiable, yet they carry deep cultural and emotional significance. The reference to “being remembered” by foreign partners, or the expression of gratitude for past engagement, points to a relational model of assistance that contrasts with the transactional logics often dominant in official development assistance.

Taken together, these findings suggest that the discourse and practices surrounding foreign development assistance are far more dynamic and contested at the local level than macroeconomic models often assume. Assistance is not simply received or rejected; it is interpreted, reshaped, and negotiated. The Zambian informants in this study demonstrate varying degrees of reflexivity and strategic engagement, reflecting both the opportunities and constraints of operating within the global development architecture.

For the development community these insights carry important implications. Foreign interventions should move beyond short-term technical assistance and towards co-created, long-term collaborations that build institutional capacity while respecting local agency. Moreover, donors and project designers must be sensitive to the symbolic and relational dimensions of assistance, recognizing that effectiveness is not merely a function of inputs and outputs, but also of continuity, trust, and dignity. The findings of this study complicate the narrative of Zambian development assistance dependency by illuminating how local actors actively shape their engagement with foreign support. Rather than viewing them as passive recipients or victims of a flawed assistance system, it is more accurate, and more ethical, to recognize their strategic choices, moral reasoning, and adaptive capacities. These insights not only contribute to the literature on assistance effectiveness but also offer a foundation for designing more equitable and responsive development partnerships in the future.

7 CONCLUSION

This bachelor's thesis examined the dependency of participants in development projects in Zambia on foreign development assistance, with a particular focus on their reliance on financial and non-financial support. The study addressed three key research questions: (1) What motivations drive diverse actors to seek and participate in foreign-funded development projects? (2) What forms of development assistance are most sought by participants in development projects? (3) What strategies do these actors employ to secure external support?

In response to the first research question, the findings revealed that actors were predominantly motivated by pragmatic needs, such as access to funding, equipment, training opportunities, and in some cases, international recognition. Many respondents perceived foreign-funded development projects as one of the few viable avenues for achieving organizational continuity or addressing urgent socio-economic needs. Their motivations were thus closely tied to institutional survival, capacity-building, and improved service delivery, but they also reflected a growing normalization of dependence on external resources.

In addressing the second research question, the data showed that the most sought-after forms of development assistance included financial support for operational costs, material resources such as equipment and infrastructure, and short-term capacity-building programs. Respondents generally favoured tangible and immediate forms of aid over more abstract or long-term interventions, such as institutional reforms or governance support. This preference appeared to be shaped both by the urgent needs of local actors and by donor programming priorities that emphasize measurable outputs over structural transformation (Todaro & Smith, 2020; Moyo, 2009).

Regarding the third research question, the research uncovered that participants employed a range of strategies to secure and maintain foreign support. These included strategic alignment with donor priorities, adaptation of project language to match donor expectations, and the cultivation of networks with foreign partners. However, the findings also showed a limited emphasis on building internal revenue mechanisms or engaging in policy advocacy, suggesting a continued reliance on donor funding as the primary means of sustaining operations. This strategic adaptation, while rational, further entrenched

patterns of dependency and weakened incentives for autonomous development planning (Easterly, 2010; Collier, 2007).

While the findings cannot be generalized across all Zambian contexts due to the localized and qualitative nature of the study, they offer meaningful insights into recurring dynamics between donors and recipients. The ethnographic approach allowed for a contextually grounded understanding of dependency as a lived and negotiated experience, rather than merely a theoretical construct. In conclusion, this research contributes to the academic discourse on foreign aid dependency by empirically demonstrating that many development actors in Zambia engage with external assistance not as a transitional tool but as a structural necessity. If development assistance is to become a catalyst for empowerment rather than dependency, a paradigmatic shift is required. Donors must invest in equitable, long-term partnerships that strengthen local autonomy and accountability. Simultaneously, recipient actors must be supported in cultivating self-sustaining strategies that go beyond donor logic and are rooted in local agency and ownership.

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ANNEXES

Annex 1: Interviews with women in Cooperative

- Q1) How long have you been part of this cooperative?
- Q2) What are your livelihoods?
- Q3) Can you describe your history in the cooperative?
- Q4) How has your life changed since you have joined the cooperative?
- Q5) What are you spending your earned money for?
- Q6) Can you afford to buy something extra?
- Q7) Does your family support you? Do your Children help you?
- Q8) How do you educate yourself?
- Q9) Are you part of any other community, cooperative or project?
- Q10) Is there anything else, you would like to tell me before we finish our interview?

Annex 2: Interviews with NGOs

- Q1) How long have you been part of this NGO?
- Q2) What are your livelihoods? What is your occupation?
- Q3) Why did you join this NGO?
- Q4) How has your live changed since you joined this NGO?
- Q5) How do you perceive elephants?
- Q6) Can you describe projects implemented in this area?
- Q7) Which projects were successful, which were not successful?
- Q8) How do your project change the community?
- Q9) Can you describe the funding mechanisms of this NGO?
- Q10) Do you have any support or cooperation with governmental organizations?
- Q11) How does environmental change affect your NGO and your work?
- Q12) What changes did you have to do because of climate change?
- Q13) What is a purpose of this NGO?
- Q14) Can you describe the relationship between tourism and local community?
- Q15) Is there anything else, you would like to tell me before we finish our interview?

Annex 3: Interviews with farmers

- Q1) What projects do you participate in?
- Q2) Have you seen any changes in your farming since you started?
- Q3) How do you adapt to climate change?
- Q4) Are you aware of any support from government or governmental project for agriculture?
- Q5) How do you educate yourself?
- Q6) How do you share gained information with other people in your area?
- Q7) Would you like to join any other project?
- Q8) Is there anything else impacting your farming in last months besides climate change?
- Q9) Is there anything else, you would like to tell me before we finish our interview?

Annex 4: Interviews with managers

Q1) How have you become part of this project?

Q2) What are your daily tasks? Can you describe your job position?

Q3) How do you perceive the environment changes in Zambia?

Q4) What are the ways the projects improve farmers lives?

Q5) Do you have any experience with dependency on the project?

Q6) Is there anything else, you would like to tell me before we finish our interview?

Annex 5: Interviews with tailors and beekeepers

Q1) Can you please tell me something about your families?

Q2) Can you tell me how does tailoring/beekeeping work here? What are your tasks?

Q3) Why did you join tailoring/beekeeping community?

Q4) What can you buy now, what you couldn't buy before?

Q5) How do you educate yourself?

Q6) How do you share your ideas with other members of community?

Q7) Where do you sell your products?

Q8) Do you have some marketing techniques to promote your product?

Q9) Is there anything else, you would like to tell me before we finish our interview?

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